

Lecture #6

the Second Exile: Rabbinic Judaism

With the defeat of Israel in 70 C. E. and the destruction of the temple a new crises of meaning and order arose for Judaism.

This crises, a situation of dissullusionment and chaos, was overcome thru a communal reaffirmation of religous faith and a reconstruction of the religious foundations of the community.

Jewish legend says that when it became obvious that Jerusalem was going to fall to the Romans, Rabbi Yohanan ben Zakkai had himself smuggled out of Jerusalem in a coffin.

he was carried to Vespasian and pleaded and received permission from the Roman commander to found an academy of rabbis at Jamnia.

Whether this legend is accurate or not, this academy of rabbis maintained stability and self-government after the defeat and exercised decisive leadership in reconstituting the Jewish people.

the Pharisaic Party is that party which came to rule after the fall of Jerusalem. The Saducees existence was tied to the temple and with the destruction they no longer existed.

With the experience of the first reconstruction of Israel behind them, the Jewish people readily accepted both the rule of the rabbis and the traditional

explanation of the latest disaster, which was they had not walked in the way of God but had become arrogant.

The ideas and institutions which emerged from the crisis of 70 reeforced the religious structure and religious self-understanding which already existed and became the permanent foundation of Jewish religious and communal life until modern times.

The rabbis gathered at Jamnia were considered to be legitimate successors of the priests and scribes, empowered to interpret the world of the Lord.

The rabbis of the Pharisaic party claimed to be the next step in a continuous chain of tradition.

descendents of the great sage Hillel became heads of the Academy at Jamnia and held power from 85 C.E. to 425 when permission to appoint a successor was denied by the Byzantine emperor.

The Jamnia community produced the laws, judges and teachers necessary for the governance of a community whose life was within the structure of the Torah.

The rabbi, from this time on, was the head of the Jewish community, rendering decisions in religious matters and wielding the authority which gave order to the life of that community.

Jews in the diaspora were organized the same way, governed by rabbis who issued decisions from their schools.

the largest diaspora community was at Babylon. The schools at Babylonia grew rapidly and renowned rabbis emerged there who would eventually become the chief authority of Jewry when the Palestinian schools declined.

in the **first** centuries C.E. all diaspora communities turned

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to Palestine.

The law was considered a gift of YHWH which established a permanent relationship between him and his chosen, and which provided a constant source of his presence to his people.

Judaism from the first concentrated upon the sphere of action, emphasizing fulfillment of God's commandments as the essential activity of the religious life.

one was

was a member of the covenant community upon obligating oneself to observing covenant law.

Commitment to God's law was

an expression of commitment to God Himself.

Every aspect of behaviour was

of behaviour was seen as an opportunity in which the Jew asserted his commitment to the Lord by fulfilling the divine will.

It was this attitude which was responsible for the development within Judaism of the **Oral** Law and the neglect of intellectual definition in the form of theology.

The distinctive religious creation of Judaism is the Halakah, the law.

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Halakah refers to a universal cosmic principle, which is contained in the Torah and its commentaries. It is really the way of the universe established by God for the governance of man. rabbinic lit. one reads that the Torah pre-existed the world and that God fashioned his creation on the basis of the Torah. God himself is said to study Torah. It is claimed that the whole universe is maintained for the sake of Torah.

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thus the most valued activity in Judaism is study and interpretation of the law.

The Mishna was issued in 200 C.E. which was a practical code of law which set definite standards in civil and religious matters. traditionally Moses was handed the 10 commandments on stone tablets but God whispered in his ear the oral interpretation of those commandments and rabbi Judah wrote them down.

The Babylonian Talmud, finished in about 500 C. E. became the authoritative code of Jewish law and the primary text of study for all later periods.

the talmud is made up of two parts. the Mishna, already mentioned, and the Gemara which was commentary on the mishna made up of the opinion of many rabbis over a long period of time. It was an effort to make the laws relevant to their own day. The Council of Jamnia in 91 C. E. decided the canon of the Hebrew Bible once and for all. protestants have followed this rendering

while the more liberal Greek and Roman Catholic churches take the septuagint text which included the intertestamental books, the apocrypha.

The underlying notion was that the total body of law could be reduced to the essential precept to love man and to love God.

Rabbi Akiba (martyred in 135 C.E. believing that Bar-cochba was the messiah and participating in a revolt) stated "Thou shalt

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love thy neighbor as thyself, that is the greatest principle of the law.

he said all of the commandments and all the Commentaries could be leveled to this essential moral precept w/o which the entire elaborate structure was meaningless.

External observance of the law was to be based upon an inner a yoke which brought freedom and purification to man. This was its true goal--spiritual perfection. intention.

It was

It is not possible to understand the continuous devotion of the Jewish community and the determined will to survive in exile unless one understands this basic religious trust and positive faith. The law was a total way of life which segregated the Jew from the environment of the non-jew.

The Halakah served to give structure legally to Jewish life and at the same time the Aggadah arose which was literature concerned with ideas and values which are the ground of that behaviour.

The Midrash is folkloristic opinions of metaphysical and

theological problems written at the same time as the legal matter contained in the Mishna.

in addition to these separate works, one third of the Babylonian Talmud and one half of the Palistinian Talmud consists of aggadic material.

Halakah and aggadah are mutually dependent since Judaism teaches there must be both objective obedience and subjective understanding.

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because of the need for understanding education becomes an Basic Talmudic Principles

1. concept of world to come.
the good suffer?

asked "why do people die and

The world to come is goal for good people, a resurreciton of the dead in which good will rise--heaven on earth.-

the goal was to worship God which meant obedience in this age and hope in the next age when all prophesies of Hebrew scriptures are fulfilled. Israel would be a priest to the rest of the nations.
nations.

The purpose of Israel was to share God with the

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New structure of authority was the rabbi. it assumes a rabbi is a scholar of the law but he must be married and earn his living at something else.

the pharasees exalted study. one rabbi said "any pious person could go to heaven but standard of piety was study. ' every formation of the law had to be reasonable.

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3. the three great sins were adultery, idolatry and bloodshed. Human beings are caught in sin and the solution was study of torah, worship of God and personal spiritual clenliness.

God manifested himself in majority rule. felt the last revelation was about 400 B.C.E. with Malachai.

there is no atonement after the temple.

4. Messianism --belief that sustained Israel was that in God's appointed hour a messiah would come to deliver Israel and

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the world from travail.

Restoration of self-rule, of the ancient city of David,
return of the exiles, and the return of God himself to
Zion—these were the ardent desires

the messianic age would be filled with glories.

first. Israel would be gathered together and restored as a
national entity to its homeland to enjoy there the bounties of
political freedom and material wealth. then the world to come
would dawn and conditions would be totally changed.

at this time a universal judgement would take place and the
righteous of all nations would be rewarded with eternal bliss

5. the synagogue replaced the temple and institution of the
every community could have one or more. the

Pharisees.

leadership were scholars and teachers so it was a place of
worship and study. the christians modelled their churches on the
synagogue.

there was no intermediary between God and human being. no
priests necessary.

Ul. Con.- living and birth in the age to come which will
fulfill the scriptures. law go forth from Zion.

High rel-God, who gives the law and reveals not only law but
himself to His people.

Hum Fred.—Sin-rebellion in particular.

We are bound in sin

of idolatry. want to set up ourselves as divine.

Solution— study the Torah, worship of God and repentance,
cleanliness of spirit.

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Religious tradition

The exile was viewed as a time of terrible suffering and
penance which the Jews had to endure in order to atone for the
sin of forgetting God's law.

Jews saw their own suffering as redemptive for mankind, in the
image of the suffering servant of Isaiah. thus they must suffer
in humility and patience

they saw the exile as a positive blessing since God offered an
opportunity to realize this historic role for which they were
chosen.

Rabbi Akiba believed sufferings were a gift of God. They
served to bring man to a recognition of his own sins, to cause
him to repent, and then to bring him to an unquestioning love of

Akiba refused to challenge divine justice believing that

whatever God did was for the good.
God.

The notion that suffering ennobled and was hence a positive value penetrated the Jewish consciousness and brought consolation to the nation.

it is this view of suffering which led Jews to accept martyrdom willingly. During the crusades, which at times led to Christian attacks against the Jews, martyrdom became an ideal act of devotion to God.

thus, their

the Jews lived in a state of constant insecurity.
historical world was that of the past, of the Bible and the Tradition, which was a spiritual world out of time but in the midst of time.

it was here that the messianic hope sustained Israel and was of primary significance in Judaism.

It was out of this also that the great schools of Jewish mysticism grew the Kabbalistic tradition. these will be discussed in a later lecture.

Medieval Jewish thinkers

In the hellenistic period, Greek ideas and values penetrated the Jewish consciousness and had a marked influence upon several levels of Jewish society.

it was under the Muslim rule, however, during the Arab conquests of the 8th and 9th Cent. that they were most deeply affected by outside influences.

thru Arab writers and thinkers, the classical tradition of Greece and the traditions of the Hindus and Persians were presented to Jewish readers.

the centuries under Islam proved to be among the most creative in Jewish cultural and religious history, producing a vast literature of a religious and secular nature.

with the rise of Islam, Jews were spurred to justify the beliefs and practices of their tradition in the rational philosophic language which would be understood by exponents of challenging beliefs.

thus from the 9th cent to the 11th, Jewish philosophic activity flourished in the Arabic lands.

there was the primary question of the role of reason within the structure of revealed religion and the relationship of

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philosophy and religious knowledg.

questions about the existence and nature of God, his

relationship to man and the role of man in the world were most significant.

for the Jew in particular, proof of the eternal and absolute truth of the Torah, and validation of the election of Israel, were of great concern.

and understanding of the commandments, both ritual and ethical,

was also demanded as part of the attempt to rationalize the entire traditional way of life.

Rabbi Saadia Gaon was the first great Jewish philosopher of the Islamic period who became head of the Academy at Sura in Babylonia in 928. His major work was The Book of Beliefs and Opinions

Saadia claimed that the truths of reason and revelation were completely harmonious. What God had revealed in the Torah could not be contradicted by knowledge which man would attain thru knowledge.

The specific value of revelation in contrast to reason was that revelation offered the truth to all men, many of whom could not otherwise attain it, and revelation, because of its final absolute nature, offered this truth in a form free of the inconclusiveness and uncertainty inherent in the process of reasoning.

Saadia believed that the exercise of reason in pursuait of a necessary and indeed a the Same basic truths was also

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religious act.

the writings of Saadia enjoyed widespread circulation among Jews in the Islamic lands and encouraged the development of Aristotelian philosophic thinking.

Moses Maimonides (1135-1384) was by far the greatest of this philosophic movement.

born in Cordova, Spain he fled with his family from anti-Jewish attacks to Fez and finally settled in Fustat, outside Cairo, Egypt where he practiced medicine.

he devoted himself to bringing together Greek philosopy and biblical revelation.

Maimonodes first book was a Commentary on the Mishnah in which he explained the concepts necessary for understanding the contents of each of the six volumes of the Mishnah, and prefaced the entire work with a chapter on the nature of Jewish tradition

as it developed from the original Mosaic revelation into the halakic and aggadic writings of the rabbis.

He intended it to be a lucid, authoritative compilation of the law and its merits were soon recognized so it became a basic guide to practice and a subject of study for all later generations.

The Guide to the Perplexed (1190) was his most famous work. it was decisive in the development of Jewish thought and greatly influenced Christian Aristotelians, such as St. Albert the Great and St. Thomas Aquinas.

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it was apologetic in nature and was addressed to his student Joseph and intended for reading by those trained in traditional Jewish disciplines, mathematics, logic and sciences who were prepared for the perils which philosophical speculation presented. Not all Jews could handle the doubts.

The first concern was the relation of faith and reason. Like Saadia he argued that natural knowledge and revelation were identical and thus there was a harmonious relation between religion and philosophy.

he considered the greatest good of man to be the attainment of knowledge, for through metaphysical knowledge of the divine reality and divine truths, man entered into a relationship of love with God and achieved communion with him.

therefore, contemplation, reflection and the pursuit of understanding were the highest values of the religious life.

this was a shift

a shift in emphasis from the traditional Jewish view which emphasized positive action based on loyal acceptance of the law.

Maimonides prescribed complete faithfulness to the ceremonial and ethical law of the Torah and assumed that philosophical study would be based upon mastery of the religious tradition but he emphasized intellectual activity and the internalization of divine knowledge as the most important.

by postulating that knowledge would lead men to imitate God and that this knowledge ought to underlie external conformity to religious imperatives, he changed the emphasis.

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Maimonides postulated certain basic beliefs, which he felt were religious truths available to everyone and necessary for the salvation of every man. These thirteen creedal articles, listed

in the commentary to the Mishnah included:

1. the existence of God; 2. the unity of God; 3. his incorporeal nature; 4. his eternity; 5. the obligation to worship God; 6. the existence of prophecy; 7. the recognition of Moses as the greatest of all prophets; 8. the acceptance of the Torah revealed to Moses as divine in origin; 9. the acceptance of the eternal validity of the Torah; 10. the notion that God is omniscient; 11. that he will reward and punish men on the basis of their actions; 12. that he will deliver men through his messiah; and finally 13. that he will resurrect the dead.

the ordinary Jew was required to affirm these beliefs and follow the commands of the Torah, whose purpose it was to lead men to an ordered moral and social life.

altogether, his rational explanation of Jewish beliefs and practices is the most thorough and complete in Jewish Literature. the intellectualization of Judaism accomplished by Maimonides with the elevation of philosophical knowledge to the rank of the greatest perfection was not accepted in certain sectors and stirred protest.

it was felt by the anti-philosophical party that human rationality could not go beyond a certain point.

during the 13th and 14th cent. the controversy between the

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advocates of philosophy and their opponents raged. It was the opponents that eventually won out, and Jewish philosophical development was largely stemmed.

Maimonides was not lost, though and still showed his influence in later centuries.

a different trend in Jewish thought was contemporary with Maimonides which was related to neo-platonism.

Judah Halevi (1085-1141/42) one of the greatest poets and thinkers of the medieval period.

in The Kuzari he endeavored to prove the uniqueness and truth of Judaism in opposition to Christianity, Islam and philosophy.

the single proof for the truth of Judaism is a historical one, according to Halevi, namely, the historical facts of God's mighty acts, his public revelation to the Jewish people, and his providential care for them.

He wrote what amounts to a creedal statement which began: "I believe in the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, who led the Israelites out of Egypt with signs and miracles;

Halevi denied that the rational intellectual efforts of man could ever reach knowledge of God. such knowledge is available only when God discloses himself because he desires to communicate with men.

God has chosen and revealed himself to Israel, the object of his greatest affection

The knowledge of the prophet cannot be reached by the philosopher, and the latter can never enter into the relationship

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of love and communion which the prophet has with God.

Since Israel has an essentially different relationship with God the ultimate redemption of the world is dependent upon the relationship of Israel to God

the pious Jew much cultivate his religious faculty since not only he but all men are drawn to salvation.

in the messianic age, what Israel alone possesses will become the property of all, and all men will enter into communion with God

For common people, the more significant writings were pietistic literature such as Bahya Ibn Pakuda's Duties of the Heart which became the standard guide to the meditational, devotional and ethical life.

he attempted to direct man toward the most intimate relationship with God which the soul could attain

his stress on the life of devotion and meditation, his emphasis upon the sentiments of trust and love rather than knowledge and wisdom, responded to the needs and exercised lasting influence upon the Jewish religious spirit. rabbinic learning, rabbinic values, and rabbinic definitions of practice always constituted the mainstream and were the base from which innovative ideas and forms emerged.

at the foundation of Jewish life was the original revelation to Moses and its interpretation by successive schools of rabbis.

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every Jew knew the scripture and was acquainted with the most lucid and brilliant commentary upon it, that of the great french scholar Rabbi Solomon bar Isaac (1040-1105) known as Rashi

with a knowledge of the Bible and Rashi, the Jew was anchored in the sacred traditions of his people, and had absorbed the religious ideas which gave meaning to his life of the community in which he participated.

Rabbi Joseph Karo (1489-1575) was the leading legalist of his day

and his legal writings have become classics in the rabbinic heritage.

He composed the Bet Joseph, four large volumes tracing the sources and development of the law and the

Shulhan Aruch a concise summary and codification of the law which became the most widely used legal guide throughout the Jewish communities of the exile.

Karo's rabbinic school was established in Safed. At the same time and in the same town, the greatest school of Jewish mysticism arose and thrived, the school of Rabbi Isaac Luria.

these two were in contact during the latter's years in Safed. Karo in fact, was involved in this mystical movement which was not uncommon for a rabbi to be both a sage and a mystic.

the great schools of mysticism will be discussed in another lecture.

worship and prayer in Judaism

the yeshivah or school became a vital

institution for the

maintenance of Jewish life in the exile and the rabbi,

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teacher and exemplar of the tradition, their society's most honored man.

soon after the destruction of 70, the task of establishing a fixed order of prayers and rituals, which would be surrogate for the Temple worship, was completed with the daily time for the services--morning, afternoon and evening--substituting for the temple sacrifices which would have been offered at those times. in addition to set prayers, scriptural readings were incorporated into the service on Mondays, thursdays, and the sabbath and festivals.

Prayer is an obligation upon every Jew, a duty to be performed at fixed times and according to a fixed ritual. more important than is one's intention (kavannah). "better is a little with kavannah than much without it"

prayer is not to be used as a magical technique to get what one wants, but it is an act thru which man can establish contact with God. In prayer man opens his heart, trusting that God does come near.

it is said that God longs for the prayers of man.

Prayer has been the fundamental religious act of piety, both preceding and going beyond rational reflection and speculation. the psalms and many other prayers were added to the liturgy over the centuries. as the Jerusalem Talmud says: God is near in all

and this is believed particularly true in kinds of nearness" prayer.

Sanctification is what the life of the religious man is devoted to, this is the act of making ordinary events and ordinary things holy.

the entire ritual order of Judaism serves to accomplish this act of sanctification in as many areas of man's life as possible.

Through the year of religious holidays and the sacred calendar which recall the moments of divine revelation and sacred acts of God, the secular or profane

or profane cycle is raised to the dimension of the sacred.

the pious Jew lives in the secular world but constantly anticipates the moments when thru participation in religious holidays, he will enter into another world, the world of the eternal and of the holy.

The Jewish ritual year is founded upon the Sabbath. this is the weekly sanctification of the creation.

the sabbath provides a constant source of renewal and

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sanctity to the pious person, who in some way is re-created him/herself as one celebrates the creation of the world.

the sabbath is thus a memorial to the work of God's creation. it is also a day of rest and time for prayer,

this keeping the sabbath is of celebration and reflection. supreme importance.

Rabbi Levi said: if the Jewish people would observe the Sabbath properly even once, the son of David (the messiah) would come.

Why? because it is equal

equal to all the other commandments in importance."

Festivals of the Jewish year

There are three festivals which are of agricultural origin, but which have been transformed into historical holidays.

Passover or Pesach is the most important which recalls the miraculous redemption from Egypt. as the passover Haggadah states:

In every generation a person is obligated to see himself as though he personally came out of Egypt, as it is written, "You shall tell your son on that day saying: This is because of what the Lord did for me when I left Egypt. It was not our ancestors alone that the Holy One, praised by Him, redeemed, but he redeemed us as well, along with them."

along with them. . .therefore we are obliged to thank, praise, laud, glorify and exalt, to honor, bless, extol, and adore Him who performed all these wonders for our fathers and for us.

This is celebrated in the Seder, a ritual meal in the home preceded by the recitation of the Exodus narrative.

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The festival of Weeks (shavout) occurs in late spring, 49 days over and celebrates the revelation of God at Sinai when after

the ten commandments were given to Moses,

The festival of booths (Sukkot) is an autumn harvest holiday and marks the historical incident of the 40 years wandering in the wilderness. the final day of this festival is a day of rejoicing in the Law because it is the end of the yearly cycle of Torah readings.

Rosh Hashanah is the new year celebration and yom kippur, the day of atonement occur close together and are a most solemn period in the Jewish year for it at this time each Jew is judged by God and his destiny for the coming year determined.

judgement is thus not reserved for a final day at the end of life, but is kmeted out every year during these critical days.

from Rosh Hashannah thru om kippur, the Jew has repented and sought mercy and comfessed sins. After a full day of prayer, the worshipper, trusting in God's mercy and goodness, finally bursts out in joyous affirmation: "The Lord is God, this God of Love, He alone is God!"

this ends the most sacred day of the religious year and people reenter the cycle of life, pruiified and hopeful.

throughout its religious history Israel has been certain of two

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things:

1. that the transcendent God was present in history and shared the feelings of his creatures and

2. that he had singled out the Jews to participate with him in bringing redemption to the world.

Jewish tradition stated that God actually needs man and this is implied in the concept of Israel's election.

this sense of God's abiding presence and the particular fate of Israel is found in the statement:

"My torah is in your hands and the end is in my hands, so that the two of us need each other. As you need me to bring on the end, so I need you to keep my Torah and to hasten the rebuilding of my house in Jerusalem" (Pesikta Rabbati 31.1445)

it was this faith in their election and the role assigned to them which inspired

Israel and gave purpose to their struggle in exile.